prospects again, the logic of strategy asserted itself in 2021. The shared desire to ensure a safer global commons and strengthen Indo-Pacific stability was appreciated at the highest levels of the four governments. The practice of holding summits of Quad leaders took off, developing rapidly in the coming years. Clearly, the Quad has now come of age.

In the bigger picture, the Quad certainly represents an example of the direction in which the world is currently moving. But to see only the outcome and remain oblivious to the reasons that drove it would be to assume that major developments happen out of the blue, which, of course, they don't.

The truth is that a large part of the explanation lies in the corrections that Indian foreign policy made after the Cold War. The changes in its strategic calculations allowed three major relationships, those with the US, Japan and Australia, to unfold more naturally and fully. This journey was not without its issues, India's own nuclear posture and economic positions, as well as the priority given by the others to Pakistan among them. When events unfolded, additional incentives for relationship-building appeared. Concern for regional stability and cooperation on global issues acquired greater salience. The last three decades also brought out the importance of values in international relations. The convergence of these major relationships on the critical challenges of our time was inevitable. And it is the resulting fusion that we now know as the Quad.

Those who ponder about the changes in the Indo-Pacific geography might find it instructive to compare them to developments in Europe three decades ago. It is something of a paradox that even though Asia has been more dynamic than Europe, its regional architecture is far more conservative. Part of the explanation lies in the fact that Europe was very much at the heart of the Cold War and felt its termination more directly. The fall of the Berlin Wall opened up the ground for strategic experimentation that has led to the expanded EU as we know it now.

In contrast, there was no such seminal development in Asia. On the contrary, this was an era of steady economic progress and an accompanying political stasis. Moreover, the region had a much vaster expanse with greater diversity and a less collective persona than Europe. In fact, there were distinct sub-regions, such as Northeast Asia, Southeast Asia, the Indian subcontinent and Oceania, each with their particular characteristics and history.